

CHRISTIANITY AND THE OCCULT

medieval Byzantine magic

After the conversion of the ruling Roman Emperor Constantine early in the 4th century, Byzantium (modern Istanbul)—the largest and richest city in Europe—became officially Christian. Most people had strong religious faith, and fervently believed in the power of Christian icons, relics, and saints to perform miracles. People are known to have chained themselves to churches in the hope of a cure for their illnesses.

Magic for ordinary people

For some time, pagan magicians lived alongside Christian clergy. The city was full of pagan statues believed to be bewitched by evil spirits, which could be manipulated, using a type of magic called *stoicheiosis*, in order to identify unfaithful husbands, pass sentences on criminals, or even clean the streets at night. The Byzantines were also firm believers in apotropaic magic—magic to ward off evil influences. They wore amulets and performed rituals to deflect the curse of the evil eye. Some people engraved stones, or wove or painted a protective image on the hems of their clothes.

Certain stones were valued for their medicinal effect, too—sardonyx (a form of onyx) was said to help prevent miscarriages, for instance.

Gradually, some churchmen took a harder line. In the 770s Emperor Leo VI issued a Novel (edict) to end tolerance of benign magic spells and amulets. A century later, the Patriarch John the Grammarian, himself accused of practicing *stoicheiosis*, led a wave of iconoclasm (the destruction of icons and statues). *Ghitevtai* (sellers of sacred objects and images to be used as amulets), and *hekantontarchos* (magicians who deceived by cunning), were increasingly driven underground.

Court magic

Magic was considered acceptable and was even used by the elite at the imperial court, despite the official status of Christianity. A number of emperors and empresses were said to have



▲ Healing stone

This 9th-century amulet mixes Christianity and magic. It shows a woman touched miraculously by Christ. The stone itself, hematite, was thought to protect against menstrual bleeding by absorbing the blood.

MICHAEL PSELLOS (c. 1017–1078)

Reconciler of beliefs

In medieval Byzantium, magic was a source of fascination and practical help for all levels of society, and many scholars studied the history of pagan occult practices. One of the most famous was the Greek monk Michael Psellos. Psellos (which means “stammerer”) was a high-ranking political adviser and eminent historian. Despite his Christian beliefs, he had an intense academic interest in the dark arts, which he called “occult” and “forbidden.” He was especially interested in astrology and the power of stones. His writings are the main source of knowledge for Byzantine magic.



Michael Psellos (left, with the emperor Michael VII) was Byzantium’s great scholar of the dark arts.